

Impact Calculus

In debate, impact calculus is a type of argumentation which seeks to compare the impacts presented by both teams. You may find that both teams have presented sound arguments that

There are three types of basic impact calculus;

- Probability, one impact is more likely than another. For example, if the Affirmative is arguing nuclear war impact and Negative is arguing a recession impact, which one is more likely to happen?
- Timeframe, one impact will happen faster or quicker than another. For example, if an asteroid impact will cause extinction before global warming will, then an asteroid impact outweighs global warming.
- Magnitude, one impact is bigger or larger than another. Nuclear war kills more people than car accidents.

Other types of impact calculus;

- Impact inclusively, one impact is inclusive of the other. For example, if global war is inclusive of a Taiwan war, therefore global war outweighs a Taiwan war.
- X creates Y, one impact causes the other impact to happen. For example, if war causes genocide, therefore war outweighs genocide.
- Internal link short circuiting, one impact prevents a (positive) impact from happening. For example, nuclear war halts space colonization; therefore nuclear war outweighs space colonization.
- Reversibility, one impact excludes something from happening. For example, civil liberties lost in the name of security during a time of crisis can be restored later, but deaths caused by a lack of security are irreversible.

Basic impact calculus arguments may be made at any time in the debate and are generally not considered "new" arguments, even if brought up for the first time in the Negative Rebuttal or Affirmative Rebuttal. More sophisticated forms of impact calculus should generally be brought up earlier in the debate and warranted if possible.